Mind the Gap: Investigating Digital Humanities Integration in Translation Studies Education

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The field of Translation Studies (TS) has undergone a significant evolution, increasingly incorporating Digital Humanities (DH) approaches alongside traditional linguistic and cultural focuses. Contemporary TS research frequently employs DH methodologies for analysing large multilingual corpora, studying translation patterns, and investigating cross-cultural phenomena, highlighting the rising importance of these methods.

However, a notable "gap" persists between these research advancements and current translation curricula. While some technologies, like Computer-Aided Translation and machine translation tools, are integrated, the educational focus remains narrow (Pym, 2013; Rodríguez-Castro, 2018). This creates a disconnect, particularly at the postgraduate level, where students often lack systematic training in the broader DH methods essential for contemporary research and professional practice despite possessing strong linguistic and cultural knowledge. This not only hinders individual development but also prevents the TS field from leveraging the unique potential of translation students. With their inherent multilingual capabilities and cross-cultural awareness, these students are uniquely positioned to address critical needs in DH, especially areas requiring multilingual data processing, cross-cultural digital archiving, and international digital scholarship. This situation underscores an urgent need for educational reform.

In response to this educational gap and the recognised potential of translation students in DH research (Wakabayashi,

2019; Sun & Li, 2020, Bowker, 2021; Gu, 2024), this study investigates the current state of DH education in TS, focusing on the understanding and perception of DH methods among postgraduate students in Hong Kong. The research is inspired by principles of digital humanities pedagogy (Hirsch, 2012)and aligns with the growing need for tech-enhanced approaches in translation education, particularly relevant in contexts like Hong Kong, where postgraduate programs are a crucial stage for developing these competencies. The study aims to propose actionable strategies for inclusive pedagogy based on the analysis of postgraduate students' experiences and expectations.

The research employed a pilot survey with 50 postgraduate students specializing in translation in Hong Kong. The survey explored their familiarity with DH tools and concepts, their perceived value of DH integration in TS, preferences for teaching methods and learning environments, awareness of ethical considerations, and anticipated impact of DH skills on career prospects. Data was collected using a mixed-methods approach, combining quantitative Likert scale questions with qualitative insights from open-ended questions.

The preliminary findings revealed a significant awareness-practice gap. While a substantial majority (60%) of respondents acknowledged the importance of DH in translation, only approximately 30% reported being relatively familiar with DH approaches. Tools such as corpus-based analysis, MT post-editing, and data visualisation were recognised as valuable but were underutilised due to limited training opportunities.

Attitudes towards the integration of DH into TS curricula were overwhelmingly positive. A large majority (81.3%) strongly supported incorporating more DH content, expressing particular interest in areas like AI-assisted transla-

tion, data analysis, and ethical practices.

Regarding preferred learning methods, students showed a strong inclination towards hands-on, experiential learning. Project-based learning was the most favoured approach (54%), followed by practical workshops (31%), highlighting the necessity of educational environments that actively engage students with DH tools.

Furthermore, the career relevance of DH skills was strongly recognised by the students, with 80% viewing these competencies as a competitive advantage in the evolving translation industry. Students also demonstrated awareness of critical ethical considerations in DH applications, including algorithmic bias, copyright issues, and inclusivity concerns.

Based on these findings, the study proposes several strategic interventions: curricular redesign to introduce specialised DH modules; hybrid learning models combining online and in-person resources; experiential learning methods like scenario-based and project-based approaches; ethical training using case-based modules; and establishing industry partnerships to provide practical experience.

The findings have important implications for the development of multilingual digital humanities and open science. Many fundamental DH tasks, particularly in multilingual contexts, still require substantial human input, such as creating multilingual metadata, curating parallel corpora, cleaning multilingual datasets, and validating machine-generated translations, tasks demanding cross-linguistic and cross-cultural expertise. The study reveals an untapped potential among translation students (80% interest vs 30% familiarity). Developing DH competencies in this group can build a workforce uniquely capable of contributing to these essential human-centred tasks in multilingual DH projects. Their combined linguistic expertise and DH literacy can significantly enhance the quality and accessibility of multilingual digital resour-

ces. This is particularly relevant as AI develops and multilingualism is increasingly valued, necessitating experts who can balance technology with human knowledge. In response to the findings, we have designed a Python programming course for translation students. In the course, students learn the curation of a multilingual corpus, the assessment of translation quality, and the connection to AI models for batch translation, all utilising information technology for large-scale processing.

In conclusion, this study focusing on postgraduate students in Hong Kong reveals a critical disparity between student interest in DH skills (80%) and their current familiarity with DH approaches (30%). This gap, coupled with a strong preference for hands-on learning and recognition of DH's professional relevance, indicates an urgent need for educational reform in translation studies. Integrating targeted DH training, particularly in areas requiring human expertise, can better prepare students for the evolving demands of digital scholarship and professional practice. These findings offer concrete guidance for translation educators and program designers developing curricula that effectively bridge technical training with traditional translation expertise. Future research could examine DH integration in diverse settings and incorporate perspectives from educators and industry practitioners.

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